

COMBAT MINDSET

Visual identity system

A subordinate identity for an Army capability framework, developed against the NZDF and NZ Army Visual Identity Guidelines v1.0.

Developed by	Army Command School and NZ Army Leadership Centre, for internal consideration
Proposed reviewers	COMDT ACS; HPC; Head of Visual Identity and Design, Defence Public Affairs
Status	Governing concept selected. Draft for review; not an approved standard.
Version	V0.6, August 2026

What this document argues

Thirteen outputs were requested. They resolve into one argument, set out below, and a specification that follows from it.

THE ARGUMENT IN FOUR STEPS

- 01

Combat Mindset is not a programme, so programme branding is the wrong precedent.

The guidelines forbid programmes creating logos. Correct, but the more useful observation is that a capability framework is closer to doctrine and controlled military information systems than to a branded project. Doctrine has a visual system: format, hierarchy, notation, numbering. That is the precedent to follow.
- 02

The identity must therefore be a grammar, not a mark.

A mark is recognised. A grammar is trusted. Personnel should know a Combat Mindset product by how it is built, not by a badge in the corner.
- 03

The organising idea is signal held under load.

The framework exists because capability degrades under pressure. The visual system should say that, structurally, in every artefact: a datum that is measured, disturbed and returned to true.
- 04

Longevity comes from structure, not style.

Rules, grids, notation and typographic hierarchy survive decades. Gradients, fields and illustrative devices carry a date stamp. The recommendation is built on the first and rations the second.

STRUCTURE OF THIS DOCUMENT

03	Position and compliance	04	Identity philosophy
05	Brand attributes	06	Visual principles
07	Selected concept: Datum	08	Considered: Threshold
09	Considered: Trace	10	Evaluation and decision
11	Title treatment explorations	12	Title treatment specification
13	Graphic language	14	Notation family
15	Colour system	16	Information architecture
17	Photography direction	18	Motion language
19	Digital application	20	Brand voice
21	Identity evolution	22	Governance and next steps

What kind of thing is this?

The single most consequential decision in this document is made here, because it determines what the identity is permitted to be.

THREE POSSIBLE READINGS, AND THEIR CONSEQUENCES

AS A PROGRAMME <i>Guidelines p34</i>	No logo. Name in plain text beside the Army logo. Nothing more. Compliant but inert. Produces no system, and no reason for anyone to trust one product over another.
AS AN ORGANISATION <i>Guidelines p9, p54</i>	A badge or unit patch. Explicitly ruled out for communication use. Non-compliant, and wrong in substance. Combat Mindset commands nothing and has no establishment.
DOCTRINE AS PRECEDENT <i>The recommended position</i>	A publication system: format, hierarchy, notation, numbering, classification. Compliant, and it borrows doctrine's enduring qualities without claiming doctrinal status. What the framework becomes is decided through the programme, not by its identity.

WHAT FOLLOWS FROM TAKING DOCTRINE AS THE PRECEDENT

- No freestanding brand mark, badge, patch or symbol. The identity is carried by typography, structure and functional notation.
- The Army logo appears unaltered on every complete formal artefact. Combat Mindset never competes with it.
- Authority is signalled the way doctrine signals it: consistent format, visible hierarchy, explicit classification of content, and a controlled identifier on every governed content item.
- Every element is specifiable in a written standard, so it can be applied by people who are not designers. This is the practical test the system must pass inside a training establishment.

COMPLIANCE POSITION

This system creates no new logo and modifies nothing in the NZDF or NZ Army identity. It uses the published Army palette, the published typefaces, and the published graphic elements. It is a subordinate application, in the same sense that a doctrine publication is a subordinate application.

It should nonetheless be put to the Head of Visual Identity and Design, Defence Public Affairs, before issue. Adopting a system without that endorsement would repeat the error this document exists to avoid.

THE PRECEDENT BEING FOLLOWED

Doctrine publications Numbered, classified, formatted identically across decades, and recognisable at a glance without a logo.	Range cards and orders formats Authority carried entirely by structure. Nobody has ever needed to brand a set of orders.	Map and chart conventions A notation learned once and applied everywhere. The reader interprets symbols never seen before.
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None of these is branded. All of them are instantly recognisable to the people who use them. That is the standard this system is aiming at.

What Combat Mindset should feel like

Not what it looks like. Feel is the harder specification and the one that determines whether the system is used or quietly abandoned.

THE FEELING TO ACHIEVE

It should feel like something that was already there.

Not launched. Not campaigned. A soldier meeting a Combat Mindset product for the first time should assume it has existed for years and that they simply had not needed it until now. Visible novelty is a liability in an enduring capability framework.

It should feel like it has been checked.

The strongest emotional response the system can produce is the quiet assumption that someone competent has been over this. That is what evidence-based means in practice: not citations on display, but the felt absence of guesswork.

It should feel calm at the moment the reader is not.

These products will be opened by people under load: before a serial, after a poor performance, during a difficult command decision. The identity must lower the temperature of the page, not raise it.

It should feel like it respects the reader's time.

Hierarchy that answers questions in the order they are asked. No persuasion, no preamble, no motivational framing. Get to the thing.

It should feel institutional rather than authored.

No individual's taste should be visible in it. The system belongs to Army, and personal signature is what makes identity systems fragile when their author posts out.

WHAT IT MUST NOT FEEL LIKE

Inspiring Motivation fades. Institutional systems endure.	Elite The framework is for the whole Army, not a selected minority.	Commercial Nothing is being sold. Nothing is being competed for.	Clever Wit in an institutional system reads as unseriousness on the second reading.
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Brand attributes

Thirteen adjectives. Each is paired with the adjective it is most often confused with, because the distinction is where the system is actually held.

THE ATTRIBUTES, AND THEIR NEAR MISSES

Measured not cautious	Precise not fussy	Composed not detached
Disciplined not rigid	Credible not authoritative in tone	Structured not bureaucratic
Clear not simplified	Enduring not old	Technical not cold
Operational not tactical in styling	Adaptive not fashionable	Human not warm
Unshowy not plain		

THE TEST

If an artefact could be mistaken for recruitment material, fitness branding, or a commercial resilience product, it has failed. If it could be mistaken for a well made doctrine publication, it has succeeded.

This is a deliberately low ceiling on expressiveness. It is the correct ceiling for a system that has to survive twenty years and four changes of sponsor.

Visual principles

Seven principles. Each is written so that a non-designer can apply it and a designer can be held to it.

THE DESIGN LANGUAGE

- 01

Everything is measured against a line.

DATUM

A single horizontal reference governs each surface. Elements align to it, hang from it or sit on it. Nothing floats. This is the structural expression of the framework's own subject: a standard held under load.
- 02

Structure is visible.

LEGIBLE
CONSTRUCTION

Rules, columns and registers are shown rather than concealed. The reader can see how the page was built, which is the visual equivalent of showing method.
- 03

Contrast carries hierarchy, not colour.

HIGH CONTRAST

Black on white, at real weight differences. Colour classifies content; it never ranks it. A page printed on a unit's mono printer must lose nothing.
- 04

Space is a material, not a leftover.

MEASURED

Generous, consistent intervals. Density is reserved for texture and never applied to text. Crowding reads as haste, and haste is the opposite of what the framework teaches.
- 05

Direction is meaningful.

DIRECTIONAL

Movement along the datum means sequence. Departure from the datum means decision. A break in the datum means risk. Direction is never used decoratively.
- 06

Complexity resolves.

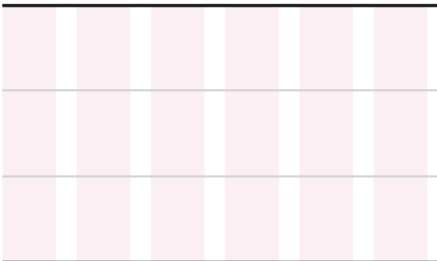
CLARITY FROM
COMPLEXITY

Where a field of competing signal is shown, it must resolve into a single clear element. Unresolved complexity is a picture of the problem, not the framework.
- 07

Restraint is the house style.

UNSHOWY

If an element cannot be justified in one sentence in the specification, it is removed. The system should look under-designed to a designer and obvious to a soldier.

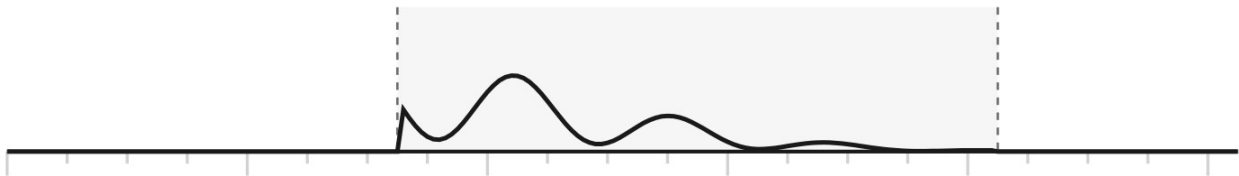


6 columns, 3 registers, one datum

The page is built from six columns and three registers, all hung from a single datum. Every surface in the system, printed or digital, is a variation on this construction.

Concept A: DATUM

A standard is held. Load displaces it. It returns to true.



SELECTED. Datum is the governing system for Combat Mindset.

THE IDEA

The page is governed by a single measured reference line. Content aligns to it. Where pressure is represented, the line deviates and then recovers. Ticks, registers and intervals come from the language of instruments, maps and range cards.

WHAT IT SAYS ABOUT THE FRAMEWORK

This is what the framework is for. Under pressure, access to trained capability can be displaced or degraded, and the system exists to preserve effectiveness and shorten the return to true.

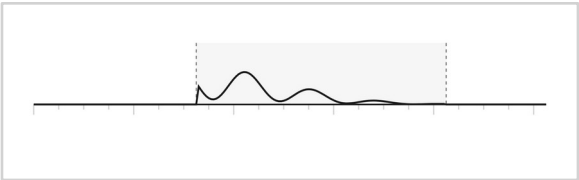
STRENGTHS

- Structural rather than illustrative, so it dates slowly. A ruled line with tick marks is as legible in 2046 as in 1946.
- Scales without loss from a favicon to a wall, because it is composed of rules rather than detail.
- Applies to non-designers. A datum and a tick interval can be specified in words and reproduced in Word, PowerPoint, HTML and print.
- Reads as instrumentation, which is the correct register for an evidence-based capability framework.

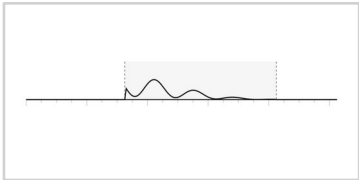
RISKS

- Quiet to the point of invisibility if applied timidly. Requires real weight contrast to carry a cover.
- Adjacent to financial and engineering identities. Distinctiveness must come from typography and colour discipline, not from the line itself.

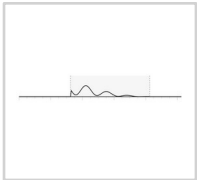
TESTED AT SIZE



Cover, 72 mm



Slide, 44 mm

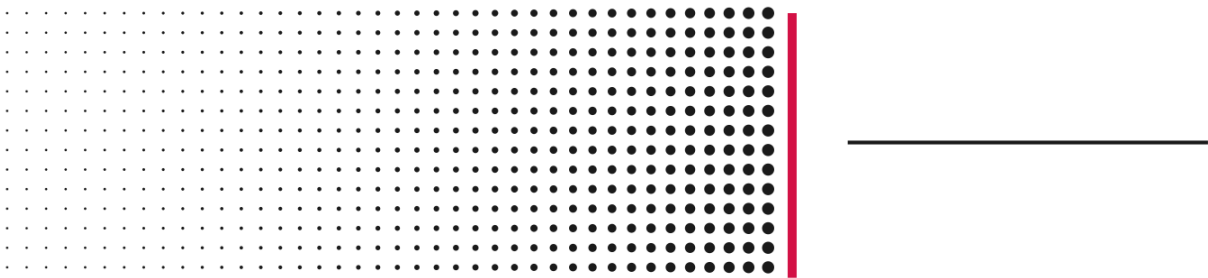


Favicon, 24 mm

The datum survives reduction because it is composed of rules. At favicon size the tick interval is lost but the line and the displacement remain legible.

Concept B: THRESHOLD

Pressure accumulates. The line holds. Beyond it, clarity.



NOT ADOPTED. The density field is retained as rationed texture only.

THE IDEA

Pressure is drawn as an accumulating density field, built from the Army halftone chevron pattern. The field intensifies towards a hard edge and stops. Beyond the edge the surface is clear and ordered.

WHAT IT SAYS ABOUT THE FRAMEWORK

The framework is the threshold. It is what stands between accumulating load and the collapse of performance.

STRENGTHS

- The most emotionally direct of the three. A reader grasps it without explanation.
- Uses an existing sanctioned Army element, so it is already inside the visual family.
- Produces striking covers and divider surfaces with very little effort.

RISKS

- Density gradients are a period signature. They read as 2015 to 2025 and will date the system within a decade.
- Hard to apply consistently at small size or in mono. The field either disappears or blocks up.
- Tends toward the decorative. Once a texture exists, it gets used everywhere, and the discipline is lost within two years.

TESTED AT SIZE



Cover, 72 mm

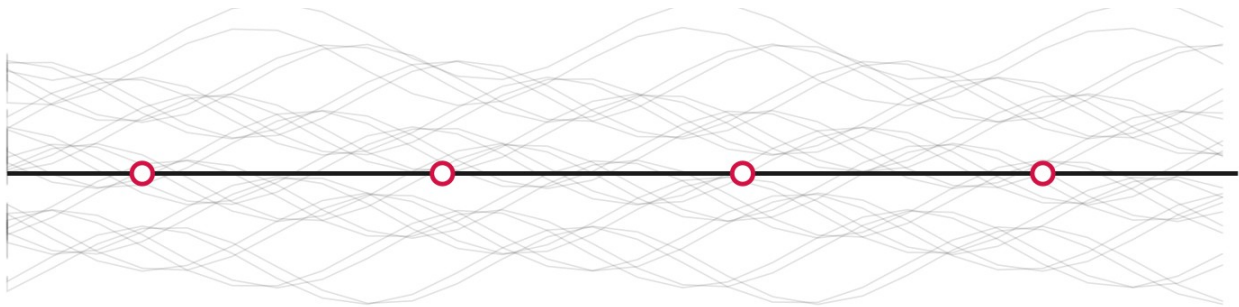
Slide, 44 mm

Favicon, 24 mm

The field collapses at slide size and reads as a grey block at favicon size. The threshold edge survives, but the idea that produced it does not.

Concept C: TRACE

One resolved path through competing signal.



NOT ADOPTED. The node and departure are retained to mark decision.

THE IDEA

A field of weak, conflicting traces sits behind a single strong path. Nodes mark the points at which the path is committed. The eye is drawn to the resolved line, not to the noise.

WHAT IT SAYS ABOUT THE FRAMEWORK

Decision under pressure is not the absence of competing information. It is the selection of one line through it, and the willingness to commit at nodes.

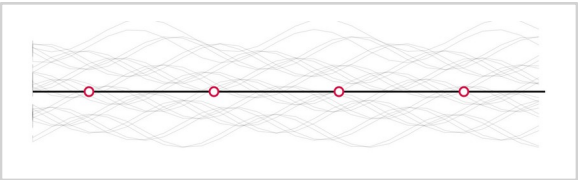
STRENGTHS

- The only concept that directly represents decision, which is central to the framework and absent from the other two.
- Gives an immediately useful device for phase diagrams, decision support and pathway documentation.
- Nodes provide a natural interactive affordance in digital products.

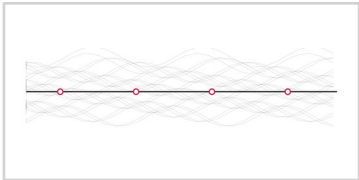
RISKS

- Closest of the three to contemporary technology branding. Without severe restraint it reads as a data-visualisation aesthetic.
- The noise field is easily overdone and becomes ornament.
- Weakest at very small size, where the field collapses into grey.

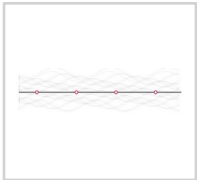
TESTED AT SIZE



Cover, 72 mm



Slide, 44 mm



Favicon, 24 mm

The noise field is the first thing to go. At favicon size the concept reduces to a plain line with dots, which is indistinguishable from Concept A.

Evaluation and decision

Scored against the criteria that matter for a system intended to last twenty years, not against which concept looks best on a cover. The decision below is taken; it is the constraint the specification is built on, not an option left open for review.

EVALUATION

	A DATUM	B THRESHOLD	C TRACE
Longevity	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	■ ■ ■ ■ ■
Scalability	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	■ ■ ■ ■ ■
Mono and small size	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	■ ■ ■ ■ ■
Applied by non-designers	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	■ ■ ■ ■ ■
Distinctiveness	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	■ ■ ■ ■ ■
Says what the framework is	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	■ ■ ■ ■ ■

DECISION

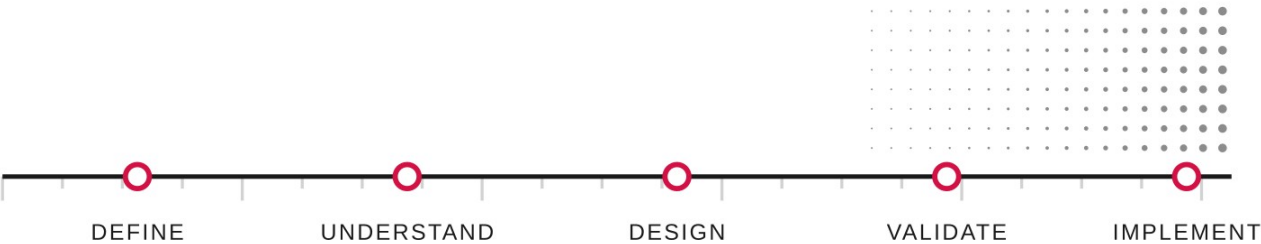
Datum is adopted as the governing system.

The node and departure from Concept C are retained as its only dynamic element, used solely to mark decision. The density field from Concept B is retained as texture, rationed to divider surfaces and never behind text. Threshold and Trace are not adopted, and are recorded so the reasons survive the people who rejected them.

WHY, AND WHAT WAS GIVEN UP

Datum wins on the criteria that decide whether a system survives. It is the only one of the three that a staff officer can reproduce correctly in PowerPoint at 2200 hours without a designer present, and that is the real durability test inside a training establishment.

What was given up is immediate emotional impact. Threshold is the stronger first impression and it was deliberately declined, because the objective stated in the brief is trust rather than recognition, and trust is built by the twentieth artefact rather than the first. Trace is the sharpest expression of decision, which is why its node was retained rather than the whole concept: adopted wholesale it would have pulled the system toward a data-visualisation aesthetic that will age badly.



The adopted system: datum as spine, nodes for decision, density rationed to texture. Shown here carrying the five phase framework development programme.

Title treatment explorations

Six typographic approaches to presenting the Combat Mindset title. None is a logo and none is a freestanding asset: these are repeatable heading constructions. Set in Arial; production is Neue Haas Grotesk.

01 STACKED MASS

Bold, tight leading, datum rule beneath.

Authority through mass. The rule anchors the mark to the system. Reads at any size and reverses cleanly.

**COMBAT
MINDSET**

02 SINGLE LINE, LETTERSPACED

Light weight, wide tracking, uppercase.

Institutional and quiet. Excellent as a running header or a spine. Too weak to carry a cover alone.

C O M B A T M I N D S E T

03 HUNG FROM THE DATUM

Rule above, mark below, aligned left.

Expresses the governing principle in the mark itself. The strongest structural fit with the system.

COMBAT MINDSET

NZ ARMY COMBAT MINDSET FRAMEWORK

04 WITH REFERENCE NUMBER

Doctrine publication convention.

Draws on doctrine-publication conventions of numbering and hierarchy. Recommended as the formal variant on covers and title pages.

CM COMBAT MINDSET

CM-FWK-001 | FRAMEWORK

05 TWO WEIGHT RELATIONSHIP

Combat bold, Mindset light.

Attempts to show the capability relationship typographically. Rejected: it implies Mindset is subordinate to Combat, which inverts the actual hierarchy.

COMBAT MINDSET

NOT RECOMMENDED

06 MONOGRAM

CM in a bounded field.

Rejected. However typographic its construction, a bounded monogram functions as a logo and would breach the guidelines and this document's own position.

CM

NOT RECOMMENDED

SELECTION

Carry 03 as the primary title treatment and 04 as the formal variant on covers, title pages and formal framework publications. Retain 02 for running headers and spines. Options 05 and 06 are recorded so that the reasons for rejecting them survive the people who rejected them.

Title treatment specification

Written so it can be applied without a designer, and audited without a debate. Deliberately not called a wordmark: this is a heading construction inside Army collateral, not a brand asset.

PRIMARY TITLE TREATMENT



CONSTRUCTION RULES

Datum rule	Width equals the treatment measure. Weight equals one tenth of the cap height. Colour black, or white when reversed. Never red.
Clear space	One cap height on all four sides. Nothing enters it, including the Army logo.
Minimum size	28 mm measure in print. 180 px in digital. Below this, use the single line variant without the descriptor.
Descriptor	One third of the title size, letterspaced 1.6. Wording settled at endorsement; until then, NZ Army Combat Mindset Framework. Omit where context establishes it; never reword locally.
Colour	Black on light grounds, white on dark. One colour only. The treatment is never red, never tinted, never outlined and never set on a photograph without a solid panel behind it.
Relationship to the Army logo	Appears on every complete formal artefact, at greater visual weight. It need not repeat inside every internal component or screen. The treatment stays outside the logo's clear space and off its baseline.

VARIANTS



Covers and title pages. Carries the reference number.



Headers, spines and footers. Single line, no descriptor.



Divider surfaces and dark applications.

Graphic language

Six elements. Nothing else is permitted, and each carries a fixed meaning so the language cannot drift into decoration.

THE PERMITTED ELEMENTS

THE DATUM <i>A single black rule, weight 1.5 pt at A4.</i>	Governs the surface. Everything aligns to it. Its meaning is a standard being held. It is never dashed, never coloured and never curved.
TICKS AND REGISTERS <i>Short marks at a fixed interval, major every fourth.</i>	Provide measure. Their presence signals that something is being assessed rather than asserted. Used on evidence, assessment and progress surfaces only.
THE NODE <i>An open circle on the datum, red stroke.</i>	Marks a decision point. It is the only element permitted to interrupt the datum, and the only routine use of red. A surface with four nodes is making four claims about where commitment occurs.
THE DEPARTURE <i>A single line leaving the datum at a node.</i>	Represents a decision taken and its consequence. Only one departure per node. Multiple departures would represent optionality, which is a different and rarer claim.
THE FIELD <i>Halftone density drawn from the Army chevron pattern.</i>	Represents accumulated pressure. Permitted on covers and dividers, never behind text, never as a page background, and never at more than 18 per cent opacity.
THE DISPLACEMENT TRACE <i>A curved deviation from the datum, black, at the datum's weight.</i>	Represents load, interference and recovery. The only curve in the system, defined so the Datum concept can be drawn without breaking its own rules. It always returns to the datum, is never red, and is never decorative.

THE GRAMMAR

Along the datum	Away from the datum	Break in the datum	Return to the datum	Density above the datum
SEQUENCE	DECISION	RISK	RECOVERY	PRESSURE
<i>Visual conventions for reading Combat Mindset surfaces, not definitions of the concepts they mark.</i>				

WHAT IS FORBIDDEN, AND WHY

- Curves outside the displacement trace. The datum itself is always straight, and no other element bends.
- Gradients other than the sanctioned halftone field. Gradients carry a date.
- Drop shadows, glows, bevels and any depth effect. Depth implies a physical object; this is a notation, not an artefact.
- Red used as a surface, a heading colour or a fill. Red marks decision nodes and defined threshold states; risk is otherwise carried structurally by the broken datum. Spending it elsewhere destroys the only signal in the system that carries urgency.
- Any new element added without an accompanying sentence in the specification stating what it means.

Notation family

Twelve marks, one grammar. These are not pictograms: nothing is a picture of a thing. Each mark is a statement about how a piece of content relates to the datum.

THE CONSTRUCTION

Every mark is drawn on a 24 unit grid at 2 unit stroke, and every mark contains the datum at y=17. What differs is what happens to that datum, and what sits on it. A reader who learns the grammar once can interpret a mark they have never seen, which is the property a pictogram set can never have. Six marks form the pilot set: Framework, Governance, Evidence, Assessment, Product and Decision, the minimum spread across the four families. Doctrine and the other marks are drafted to prove the grammar extends, and join when authority arrangements and repository content warrant them.

FOUR FAMILIES

STRUCTURE Content that carries authority. The datum is complete and unbroken.	ANALYSIS Content that examines. The datum carries measures, intervals or returns.	DELIVERY Content that is used. Discrete objects sit on the datum.	ACTION Content that requires a person to do something. The datum is left or broken.
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THE TWELVE MARKS

PILOT  FRAMEWORK STRUCTURE The governing architecture. Used once, at the top of a hierarchy.	 DOCTRINE STRUCTURE The solid bar: endorsed institutional guidance rather than open inquiry.	 POLICY STRUCTURE Bounded above and below: the convention for rules that carry limits.	PILOT  GOVERNANCE STRUCTURE Brackets on both sides. Something is being held, not merely described.
PILOT  EVIDENCE ANALYSIS Rising measures. Evidence accumulates and is read against the datum.	 RESEARCH ANALYSIS An open bracket and a dashed continuation. The question is not yet closed.	PILOT  ASSESSMENT ANALYSIS A measured gap. Assessment is the act of reading the interval.	 REVIEW ANALYSIS A return to a prior point. Review is deliberate, not repetition.
PILOT  PRODUCT DELIVERY A block on the datum. Products are discrete, identifiable and issued for use.	 REFERENCE DELIVERY A single tick and a marker. Points elsewhere; carries no authority itself.	PILOT  DECISION ACTION A node and a departure. The only mark that leaves the datum.	 RISK ACTION A break in the datum identifies risk. A reading convention, not a definition.

AT SIZE, AND IN MONO

 48 32 24 16 px	 in classification colour	 mono, meaning intact
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Colour system

No colour is invented. Every value is published in the NZ Army Visual Identity Guidelines p58. What is added here is a set of rules about what each colour is allowed to mean.

PRIMARY

Black #000000 Process Black C rgb 0 0 0	White #FFFFFF White rgb 255 255 255	Army Red #D31145 Pantone 200 C rgb 211 17 69
Structure, type and the datum. The default. Carries all hierarchy.	Space, and the reversed state. Space is a material and is budgeted, not filled.	Decision nodes, the action notation, and defined threshold states. Otherwise risk is carried by the broken datum.

SECONDARY: CLASSIFICATION, NOT DECORATION

ANALYSIS 5605 C #00261B	DELIVERY 5747 C #444D06	LAYERING 5853 C #B3A650	GROUND 5855 C #DFD8AD
Evidence, research, assessment, review.	Products, references, training material.	Secondary surfaces, table banding, inactive states.	Panels and callouts beneath text. Never text itself.

PROPORTION RULE



Red never exceeds five per cent of any surface. This is the only hard numerical constraint in the colour system, and it is the one that keeps the signal working. A page where red marks four decision nodes tells the reader something. A page where red also carries headings, rules and callouts tells them nothing.

MONO AND ACCESSIBILITY

- Every artefact must survive a mono print with no loss of meaning. Classification is therefore carried by the notation mark as well as by colour, never by colour alone.
- Body text is black on white or white on black. The greens are never used for running text.
- Army Red on white calculates at roughly 5.3 to 1, which passes AA for body text; Army Red on black fails and is not permitted for type. Every claim here is re-verified with accredited tooling at step 03, and the repository tests contrast, minimum sizes, mono output and reduced motion automatically.
- Colour blindness affects roughly one in twelve men. Red against the four greens is the least safe pairing in the palette, which is a further reason red is reserved for a marker shape rather than a fill.

Information architecture

Twelve content types, each with a fixed treatment. A reader should be able to tell what kind of thing they are holding before they have read a word of it.

THE COMPONENT

Every piece of Combat Mindset content is presented in the same component: a notation mark, a type label, an identifier, a title, and a status line. The component is identical in print, in a slide, in a repository and on a phone; only its scale changes. Identifiers separate content type, item and version, because a number that means two things eventually means nothing. The scheme shown is illustrative: allocation authority, and its relationship to existing Army and NZDF reference series, is resolved at step 03 before any identifier is issued. The pilot also tests whether some types are better held as status or relationship metadata than as primary types.



EVIDENCE

CM-EVD-004 v0.3

Cognitive load and decision quality under physical stress

Endorsed | Reviewed Aug 2026 | Owner NZALC

notation type and reference title and status

THE TWELVE TREATMENTS

	FRAMEWORK	STRUCTURE	CM-FWK-001	Governing architecture
	DOCTRINE	STRUCTURE	CM-DOC-001	Endorsed and enduring statements
	POLICY	STRUCTURE	CM-POL-001	Rules with limits
	GOVERNANCE	STRUCTURE	CM-GOV-001	Who holds and assures what
	EVIDENCE	ANALYSIS	CM-EVD-001	Findings and their strength
	RESEARCH	ANALYSIS	CM-RES-001	Open questions and method
	ASSESSMENT	ANALYSIS	CM-ASM-001	Measurement against a standard
	REVIEW	ANALYSIS	CM-REV-001	Deliberate return to a prior position
	PRODUCT	DELIVERY	CM-PRD-001	Material issued for use
	REFERENCE	DELIVERY	CM-REF-001	Pointers to work held elsewhere
	DECISION	ACTION	CM-DEC-001	A point at which commitment is required
	RISK	ACTION	CM-RSK-001	A discontinuity to be managed

Greyed rows are candidate extensions: drafted to prove the grammar extends, and introduced only when the pilot shows the distinction is needed.

Photography direction

Photography is the element most likely to break this system, because it is the element most often chosen by someone in a hurry. The direction below is written to be enforceable.

THE GOVERNING INSTRUCTION

Photograph the load, not the outcome.

The framework is about what happens to people under pressure. The imagery should show pressure being carried, not victory being celebrated.

DIRECTION

LIGHTING	Available light only. Overcast, dawn, dusk, interior fluorescent, vehicle interior. No fill, no flash, no colour grading beyond correction. If the light was poor, the photograph shows poor light.
COMPOSITION	Eye level. The camera stands where another soldier would stand. High and low angles are permitted only where the operational reality requires it, never for drama.
FRAMING	Wide enough to show the environment doing the work. The context is the pressure; a tight portrait removes the very thing being documented.
SUBJECT	The whole Army. Ranks from private to colonel, all trades, all body types, both regular and reserve. If the imagery set skews young, male and infantry, the framework will be read as belonging to them.
EMOTION	Concentration, fatigue, recovery, deliberation, the flat expression of someone thinking hard. Never aggression, never triumph, never the shouted moment.
MOMENT	The moment before or the moment after. The moment itself is almost always the least informative frame and the most theatrical.
EYE CONTACT	None, except in a named environmental portrait where a person is being quoted or credited. A soldier looking into the lens is performing.
POST	Correction only. No vignettes, no crushed blacks, no teal and orange, no monochrome conversion to add gravity.

AUTOMATIC REJECTIONS

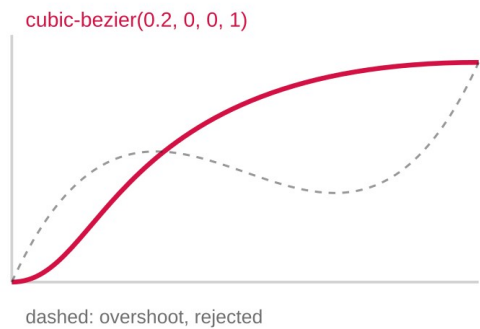
Silhouettes against a sunset	Generic gym imagery as shorthand for performance	Weapon-forward hero framing	Shouted faces
Staged planning shots around a map	Stock imagery of any kind	Anything shot for recruitment	Composites and montage

Motion language

Motion is the newest part of the system and the part most likely to date it. The specification is therefore deliberately narrow.

THE PRINCIPLE

Motion confirms. It does not perform.



Easing	cubic-bezier(0.2, 0, 0, 1). Decelerate into position. No overshoot, no bounce, no elastic.
Duration	180 ms for state change. 240 ms for element entry. 320 ms for view transition. Nothing exceeds 400 ms.
Entry	Elements arrive along the datum, by wipe or by translation on one axis. Nothing fades in from nowhere and nothing scales up.
Emphasis	A node may draw its stroke once, in 240 ms, on first appearance only. It never pulses, never loops and never glows.
Reduced motion	Honour the operating system preference. With reduced motion set, every transition becomes an instant state change with no substitute effect.

WHY SO NARROW

Every generation of interface has an animation signature, and it is always the first thing that makes an old product look old. Skeuomorphic easing dated in five years. Material motion dated in seven. A system intended to run for twenty must spend as little as possible on motion, so that when the signature of this decade becomes visible, there is almost nothing of it to remove.

FORBIDDEN

- Parallax, particles, glow, blur transitions, and anything that draws attention to the transition itself.
- Looping animation of any kind. A loop is a demand for attention, and these products are read by people who have somewhere to be.
- Motion that conveys information not otherwise available. If a reader with reduced motion enabled loses meaning, the design has failed.
- Animated logos or title treatments. The title treatment is a fixed thing; animating it makes it a performance.

Digital application

The system is digital-first, which means the specification must survive contact with markdown, a repository theme and a phone screen.

APPLICATION BY SURFACE

01 REPOSITORY AND GITHUB DOCUMENTATION

Markdown is the constraint. The notation family is issued as inline SVG so a mark can precede a heading in a README without an image pipeline. The datum becomes a horizontal rule. The reference number goes in the front matter and the file name, so a document remains identifiable when detached from its interface.

02 FRAMEWORK BROWSER

The pilot content types form the initial primary filter, not a search box. A user arrives asking what kind of thing they need before they know its title. Left rail carries the notation; content pane carries the component.

03 CONTROLLED CONTENT READER

Endorsed text at full measure, with evidence and assessment collapsed beneath it and marked with their own notation. Doctrine is one content class this reader eventually carries. The reader can see that evidence exists without being made to read it, which is the behaviour the framework wants to encourage.

04 DECISION SUPPORT

The only place the departure element is used interactively. A node expands to show what commitment at that point entails. No wizard, no scoring, no recommendation engine; the tool documents the decision, it does not make it.

05 DASHBOARDS

Ticks and registers, black on white, no chart junk. Red marks only thresholds crossed. A dashboard where several things are red is reporting a genuine problem, not a styling choice.

06 PRESENTATIONS

One template, three slide types: statement, component list, diagram. The datum runs across every slide at a fixed height so a deck reads as one continuous surface.

07 TRAINING PRODUCTS

Printable at unit level on a mono printer. Every classification survives without colour because the notation carries it. This is the constraint that most often breaks identity systems in a training establishment, and it is designed for rather than discovered.

08 MOBILE

Single column, datum at the top of the viewport, notation at 24 px. Content types collapse to the mark and the reference number. Offline first, because the reader is frequently somewhere without signal.

THE SINGLE SOURCE

The specification, the notation family, the colour tokens and the component markup are held in one repository and consumed by every surface. Nothing is redrawn per product. This is what makes the twenty year claim credible: the identity is maintained as code with a version number, not as a PDF that people copy from.

Brand voice

The identity fails at the first sentence if the writing does not match it. Voice is specified here as pairs, because writers learn faster from contrast than from adjectives.

HOW COMBAT MINDSET SPEAKS

Confident	It states. It does not argue with an imagined sceptic, and it does not hedge every claim into meaninglessness.
Measured	Short sentences. One idea each. The register of a good set of orders, not a good speech.
Evidence-based	Claims carry their strength. Where the evidence is thin, the text says so, because a framework that overclaims once is discounted permanently.
Operational	Written for someone who will act on it. Every paragraph should survive the question: what does the reader do differently now.
Plain	No jargon that a corporal would have to look up, and no psychology terminology used decoratively.
Never motivational	It does not exhort, inspire, challenge or remind anyone what they are capable of. The moment it does, it becomes a poster, and posters are ignored.

WRITE THIS, NOT THAT

WRITE

Under pressure, trained people lose access to capability they demonstrably hold.
The evidence for transfer to operational performance is currently limited.
Phase 2 assesses existing products against the endorsed outcomes.
Do this before the serial. Record what happened. Review it within 48 hours.

NOT

Unlock your true potential when it matters most.
Proven to deliver results on operations.
We are on an exciting journey to transform how Army thinks about performance.
Embrace the challenge and push through your limits.

THE TAGLINE

Remain effective. Act decisively. Harder to kill. It works because the first two lines are instructions and the third is a consequence, not a boast. It should be used sparingly, on covers and dividers, and never as a heading inside a document. Overused, it becomes the motivational register the rest of the voice is written to avoid.

Identity evolution

How the system matures over ten years, and why it should never need a redesign.

THE MECHANISM

The system is a grammar, not a set of assets. New content types are added by extending the notation according to the existing rules, not by commissioning new marks. New surfaces are built from the datum, the grid and the component. Because meaning lives in the grammar rather than in any particular drawing, the drawings can be replaced without the identity changing.

NOW 2026 to 2028

Specification issued. Title treatment, grammar, notation, colour and templates.

NEXT 2029 to 2032

Notation extended as new content types appear. No redesign.

ENDURING 2033 to 2046

Typeface and medium may change. The grammar does not.

WHAT IS ALLOWED TO CHANGE, AND WHAT IS NOT

MAY CHANGE

- The typeface, if NZDF changes its own. The system specifies weight relationships and measure, not a named font.
- The medium. Print, web, native application, whatever follows. The component survives the transport.
- The notation set, by extension. New marks are added when new content types genuinely appear.
- Photography, continuously. Imagery should always look like this year's Army.

MUST NOT CHANGE

- The datum itself. It is the governing device, selected against five criteria, and the system has no second spine.
- The meaning of the grammar. Away from the datum is decision, permanently.
- The reservation of red for decision, action and defined threshold states, with risk otherwise identified structurally by the broken datum. This is the single constraint that keeps the system readable.
- The primacy of the Army logo, and the absence of a Combat Mindset logo.
- The requirement that every artefact survives a mono print.

THE FAILURE MODE TO WATCH FOR

Identity systems in defence do not usually die of obsolescence. They die when a capable person arrives, finds the system constraining, and improves it locally. Within three years there are four versions and the signal is gone. The defence against this is not enforcement, it is making the specification good enough, and available enough, that improvising is more work than complying.

Governance and next steps

What this document is, what it is not, and what would have to happen for it to become a standard.

STATUS OF THIS DOCUMENT

This is a proposal, not an approved standard.

It was developed inside ACS and NZALC against the published guidelines. It has not been reviewed by Defence Public Affairs, and no part of it should be issued as authoritative until it has been.

SEQUENCE

01

Internal agreement on position

ACS, NZALC, HPC

Agree that doctrine and controlled information systems are the visual precedent, without claiming doctrinal status for the framework itself. The governing concept is settled: Datum is adopted, and the review is not asked to reopen it. No production assets or enduring templates should be issued before the position is agreed.

02

Review by Defence Public Affairs

Head of Visual Identity and Design

Put the position, the adopted concept and the specification to DPA. Expect challenge on the title treatment, the notation family, and the derivation of the field from the Army chevron pattern. Obtain the vector Army logo at the same time.

03

Specification written

ACS with a design agency

Convert this document into a written standard with measurable rules, plus the asset set: notation SVGs, colour tokens, component markup, templates.

04

Pilot on real products

The framework proposal and ELDA material

Apply it to two live products before issuing it. A system that has never been used is a system that has never been tested.

05

Issue and version

NZALC as custodian

Publish under a validated identifier with a version number and a named owner. Review annually, extend by amendment, and resist redesign.

THE TEST TO APPLY IN TEN YEARS

Open two Combat Mindset products made a decade apart, by different people, in different media. If they are recognisably the same system, and neither looks like it is trying to persuade anyone of anything, the identity has done its work.